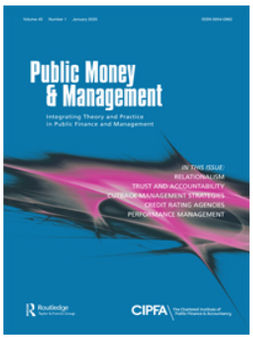

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New development: Assessing the influence of Brazil's public governance narrowness on the Brazilian Army

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IMPACT

This article addresses the challenges non-English-speaking countries face in implementing imported policies and how Brazil's federal-level understanding of governance impacts sectoral public organizations. The authors' focus is on the impacts on the Brazilian Army, an understudied organization among public administration scholars, which is often called to operate in areas other than defence policy. The insights provided in the article will help researchers, policy-makers, and practitioners to navigate such challenges by advocating for a more transparent policy debate and fostering context-specific approaches to governance.

ABSTRACT

Concerns have been raised in *Public Money & Management* about Brazil's narrow view of governance and its disregard for networks. The authors extend this debate, investigating its effects on the Brazilian Army's governance norms and structures and whether network dynamics play a role in the army's operations. A narrow understanding of governance was discovered to persist. However, networked action exists under other-than-governance labels.

KEYWORDS

Brazilian Army; Brazilian Federal Court of Accounts (Tribunal de Contas da União: TCU); networked action; participation; public governance

Introduction

'Governance' emerged in Brazil, promising to address public administration challenges and enhance social control over public policies. However, as Caldeira et al. (2022) and Grin (2023) noted, Brazil defined governance mostly as a toolkit for improved management, emphasizing bureaucratic control over public policies, and combining elements from the OECD's corporate governance (OECD, 2015) and the World Bank's good governance (World Bank, 1992). Additionally, creating a public governance policy centred in its supreme audit institution—the Federal Court of Accounts (the TCU: Tribunal de Contas da União)—increased the long list of criteria for public organizations to meet external control standards, lacking acknowledgement of networks and a closer public–private relationship (Grin, 2023; Stoker, 1998).

In this article, we explore the repercussions of this narrow perspective of governance on public organizations in Brazil, with a specific focus on the Brazilian Army—an understudied organization often called on to operate in other policy sectors while being highly bureaucratized. Our secondary objectives are fourfold: first, we contribute with insights into the issues raised by Caldeira et al. (2022) and Grin (2023), setting expectations for the Army case. Second, we examine diverse governance definitions and principles within Brazil's normative landscape to understand the Army's relative position. Third, we scrutinize how the Army's governance structures align with existing perspectives. Lastly, we present evidence on how the Brazilian Army addresses networks and public–private interactions which are overlooked in federal governance norms.

Brazil's take on governance and its implications for the Army

Recent debates in *Public Money & Management* stated that Brazil's governance is a mix of good governance and corporate governance concepts from organizations such as the OECD and the World Bank that fail to encompass the 'horizontal relationship between public and private actors in designing and managing public policies' (Caldeira et al., 2022, p. 1) and its collaborative nature (Caldeira et al., 2022; Grin, 2023; OECD, 2015; World Bank, 1992).

TCU conceived Brazil's current governance model in the 2013 document 'Basic Governance Framework for Public Administration' (TCU, 2013), which has consistently spread throughout the country's public agencies due to the sanctioning character of its creator. This model is also present in Brazil's latest legislation, notably in Decree No. 9,203 (2017), which sets out Brazil's federal government's public governance policy. It defines 'governance' as the combination of leadership, strategy and control mechanisms to assess, guide, and oversee management, public policies, and services—this is the exact TCU definition.

However, the 2017 regulation brought some innovations. It added six new governance principles—responsiveness, integrity, reliability, regulatory improvement, accountability, and transparency—reflecting efforts to align with OECD standards for Brazil's membership bid in 2017 (Caldeira et al., 2022). Noting the insufficiency of the decree on explaining how these principles should be implemented, the Office of the Chief of Staff of the Presidency (Casa Civil da Presidência da República) released a guide on public governance policy, providing their detailed explanation (Casa Civil, 2018).

The TCU holds enforcement powers of such policy, conducting audits and penalizing non-conformities. Grin (2023) found that the prominence of TCU in this field resulted from three factors: a critical political situation resulting from the loss of governmental legitimacy due to a series of corruption scandals; the dissemination of international models promoting audit courts as critical

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players to build trust in public administration; and the TCU's presumed role as a representative of society in social control.

We wanted to understand the implications of this panorama for the Brazilian Army. We set two field expectations to be analysed. First, we anticipated a stronger emphasis on governance as control and bureaucratic planning, deepening what the literature on Brazil's governance policy describes as a strict separation between those responsible for governance and those handling administration, resembling bureaucratic control and corporate governance *modi operandi* (Martins et al., 2022). In this sense, the focus on control and bureaucracy may overshadow practices related to governance that are more distant from those paradigms, such as vertical transparency and better public–private and whole-of-government co-operation (Rodrigues, 2020; Duarte, 2022), possibly due to historical institutional characteristics like bureaucratic insulation, administrative autonomy, and limited social participation in defence policy (Duarte, 2022).

Second, we expected that the Army would exhibit a more robust normative approach to networked action—both with other private and state agents, more aligned with the theoretical perspective of governance (Stoker, 1998), than Brazil's public governance normative, stemming from defence sector-related factors like the emergence of new threats (Covarrubias, 2004), the necessity for joint operations training envisioning future wartimes, the frequent civilian requests for military assistance in areas beyond their primary responsibility (requiring collaboration with other agencies), and the imperative to secure borders (another inter-agency activity).

Both articles (Caldeira et al., 2022; Grin, 2023) agree that collaboration and networks between the state and society are missing in Brazil's governance. Indeed, its meaning is reduced by restricting the understanding of governance to a few management functions commonly found in corporate governance, especially considering the vast literature on the topic (Caldeira et al., 2022; Cavalcante & Pires, 2018; Grin, 2023; Stoker, 1998; Milward & Provan, 2000; Ansell & Torfing, 2022).

However, we aim to expand Grin's (2023) understanding of participation in governance. In our view, governance is about transcending institutional and sectoral boundaries when responding to social problems (Aoki et al., 2023; Stoker, 1998), not necessarily linked to a hollow-state perspective of governance that automatically leads to outsourcing (Peci et al., 2008; Milward & Provan, 2000), neither to predefined vertical participation designs. According to Fung (2006), participation should clearly enhance legitimacy, justice, and effective administration. For that, it should be context-sensitive, with different configurations of who participates, how ideas are communicated and decisions made, and who has the authority and power to implement decisions.

This broader governance perspective may not encompass all forms and depths of participation (Fung, 2006) but can range from diffuse and indirect involvement to co-governance. This includes multi-actor arrangements within the state, aligning with whole-of-government and joined-up government principles: concepts which, although nuanced, can be interchangeable (Christensen & Lægreid, 2007; Bogdanor, 2005; Aoki et al., 2023), to deeper integration with society and private institutions, akin to whole-of-society approaches. In this sense, Brazil's federal government's perspective of governance underestimates not only intragovernmental collaboration but also co-operation with the private sector and civil society.

Comparing perspectives of governance: the federal government, the TCU and the Army

The Army's governance and management policy aims to 'establish principles, objectives, and general guidelines to enhance and integrate the structures and mechanisms of governance and management of the Institution, contributing to the increased operability of the Brazilian Army' (Ordinance No. 987, 2020, p. 24; our translation).

As shown in Table 1, there is a convergence of understanding, at least at the definition level, among TCU, the federal decree, and the Brazilian Army Governance Policy (Ordinance No. 987, 2020). This is because the triad of governance mechanisms—'leadership, strategy, and control'—is present in all definitions, and sets the tone for the policy at all analysed levels.

The TCU (2020) introduced 'equity and participation' to the existing principles in Decree No. 9.203; and the Brazilian Army Governance Policy (Ordinance No. 987, 2020) introduced ethics, integrity and process improvement as separate principles. Notably, compared to TCU and the Federal Government's normative, the Brazilian Army is distinctive in explicitly mentioning networked action by adding an 'integration' principle, ensuring that military organizations are interconnected, interactive, and interdependent in various management practices within the institution.

Table 1. Brazil's varying governance definitions and principles.

	Definition of governance	Principles of governance
Federal Court of Accounts (TCU) (2020)	'Organizational public governance essentially encompasses the leadership, strategy, and control mechanisms implemented to assess, guide, and monitor management activities, aiming to steer public policies and deliver services in the interest of society' (p. 36; our translation).	Responsiveness, integrity, transparency, equity and participation, accountability, reliability, and regulatory improvement (p. 44; our translation).
Decree No. 9.203: the Public Governance Decree (2017)	'The set of leadership, strategy, and control mechanisms put in place to evaluate, direct, and monitor management, conduct public policies, and provide services of interest to society' (our translation).	Responsiveness, integrity, reliability, regulatory improvement, accountability, and transparency (our translation).
Brazilian Army Governance Policy (Ordinance No. 987, 2020)	'The set of leadership, strategy, and control mechanisms implemented to assess, guide, and monitor management activities, aiming to steer public policies and deliver services in the interest of society' (p. 25; our translation).	Reliability, responsiveness to public interest, ethics, integrity, process improvement, accountability, transparency, and integration (p. 27; our translation).

Source: Authors.

Army's governance structures

The Brazilian Army Governance and Management Directive created the Army Governance and Management System (SG^2Ex) as the institution responsible for implementing governance policy within the Army (Ordinance No. 465, 2021). Its structure comprises two axes: governance and management.

Governance axis

The *governance axis* is located at a strategic level, covering the senior administration of the institution—four-star General Officers in service. Its central governance agency is the Brazilian Army General Staff (EME); this agency is responsible for the institution's general guidelines.

EME has an Advisory on Governance and Management (AGM) tasked with 'implementing, maintaining, coordinating, monitoring, and evaluating governance and management practices, tools, and activities at the strategic level' (2021). The AGM plays a key role in producing a crucial accountability tool, the Brazilian Army Management Report (RGCE), which is mandatory and subject to TCU's scrutiny.

Governance and management advisories in sectoral direction organs and the organs of direct and immediate assistance to the commander of the Army are responsible for monitoring governance activities. These advisories create and assess operational and sectoral governance and management plans.

Management axis

The management axis is located at operational and tactical levels, including military area commands, military regions, brigades and battalions. The Brazilian Army governance and management directive (Ordinance No. 465, 2021) recommends establishing management advisory or management teams within their internal structures to create management plans. These plans are typically available online (but not necessarily easy to find), and their content focuses on management aspects like strategic planning, organizational values, and assessments of the organizational 'vision for the future'.

The same directive mentions the Army's Governance, Risks, and Controls Committee. Its duties are defined in the Brazilian Army Risk Management Policy (Ordinance No. 004, 2019). Its composition is limited to strategic-level members and prioritizes risk management and internal control more than governance.

Evaluating the implementation of the Army's governance policies is difficult since it lacks vertical accountability and transparency. The Army's websites on governance and management commonly offer only a compilation of legislation. Additionally, the AGM lacks a website. Information about its activities is only accessible through institutional news pieces on the Brazilian Army website. This is a black box yet to be opened.

In conclusion, the governance triad (direct/monitor/evaluate) guides the strategic level activities. In contrast, the operational and tactical levels handle tasks related to the management triad (plan/execute/control). This highlights the adoption of the prescriptive-normative model found in federal government guidelines, especially those of the TCU. Governance and management are separated as in the corporate governance approach and are associated with controlling management (Martins et al., 2022). In this sense, the Army's governance structure confirms our first expectation that Brazil's narrow perspective of governance prevails in the Army.

Beyond the governance label: the Army's and the Ministry of Defence's (MOD) norms on networked action

If Brazil's governance approach lacks both public–private and networked action, does it mean it does not exist in its public administration? Not necessarily. Two inter-agency manuals are worth mentioning: the one elaborated by the MOD and the one elaborated by the Brazilian Army. The first is the MOD's second edition of the Manual on Inter-agency Operations, the 'MD33-M-12' (Ordinance No. 32, 2017). The second is the Army's second edition of the Field Manual on Inter-agency Operations, the 'EB70-MC-10.248' (Ordinance No. 181, 2020).

The first editions of the MOD's and Army's inter-agency manuals predate the 2017 Governance Decree—both were published in 2013. In all their versions, including the updated manuals of 2017 (MOD) and 2020 (Army), there is no mention of the word 'governance'. However, the prefaces to both manuals emphasize the significance of co-operation among diverse agencies and private organizations in inter-agency operations.

The 2017 MOD's manual for inter-agency operations provides a definition that encompasses the missing networked public–private collaboration. The manual sets out its purpose as follows: 'Establishing doctrinal foundations that will guide the Armed Forces in the planning, preparation, and employment process in joint operations (JO) *involving the participation of public agencies, non-governmental organizations, private companies, or agencies from other branches of government in the execution of actions'* (2017, p. 13; our translation, our emphasis).

The Brazilian Army's Field Manual on Inter-agency Operations (2020) follows the same rationale, giving more detailed information regarding documents and plans that should be formalized within the Army's military organizations.

Figueiredo et al. (2023) state that the MOD's inter-agency manual is the sole manual on the topic at a ministerial level in Brazil. Other non-defence government agencies have adopted it. However, the authors argue that the manual may reinforce a centrally controlled type of co-operation, potentially excluding more decentralized forms of networked action. Critics also argue that these operations within and led by military institutions lack an effective lessons-learned system and often limit the participation of some agencies in the process and the decision-making processes (Figueiredo et al., 2023).

However, there is still a need for study cases and structured comparisons in this regard, since there is evidence of network arrangements with both public and private agencies in various armed forces operations led by the Army. These include:

- The Federal Intervention in the Public Security of Rio de Janeiro State, in an inter-agency effort to co-ordinate its civil and military police (GIFRJ, 2019).
- Operation Covid 19, which involved the support and integrated logistics with dozens of municipalities, local organizations, suppliers and the Ministry of Health in several Brazilian regions (Gröhs et al., 2020).
- Operation Acolhida that, to respond to significant Venezuelan immigration into Brazil, has been working with municipalities and state governments and also with international human rights institutions (Franchi, 2019).
- The Cyber Guardian Exercise (*Exercício Guardião Cibernético*), conducted yearly by the Army's Cyber Defence Command, which had more than 500 civilian and military participants and around 111 private companies and organizations participating in 2023 (Liz, 2023).

Final considerations

We discussed two preconceptions in this article. Our first focused on governance principles, anticipating an alignment between traditional bureaucratic control and planning and the Army's governance structure. This expectation was met, as the structure emphasized a clear division between governance and management, prioritizing hierarchical structures for effective management. It supports Caldeira et al. (2022) and Grin's (2023) concerns regarding the potential adverse effects of Brazil's narrow governance perspective on the sector.

Our second preconception addressed the absence of networks, private sector and civil society participation in Brazil's governance policies, following Caldeira et al. (2022) and Grin's (2023) assertions. We anticipated a more developed normative for the Army than the national normative. The Army exhibits greater development, first, by incorporating the 'integration' principle into its governance policy. Second, inter-agency norms include other public and private agencies, and there is abundant *de facto* evidence of inter-agency operations where the Army participates and leads. Hence, we should not presume the absence of networked action, whole-of-government planning, public–private collaboration, and civil society engagement in Brazil solely due to the country's limited governance perspective. In this regard, we emphasize the need for clarity and a deeper theoretical debate regarding participation in complex governance settings, where different participation configurations can enhance democracy and policy effectiveness.

This underscores the necessity for future studies encompassing differences in implementation design among policy sectors, analysing if already existing policy networks dialogue with governance policies. These analyses should also assess how the direction of evaluation and enforcement by comptrollers can affect the whole implementation of the policy by leaving the depth of implementation of unsettling governance principles to each entity's discretion, such as transparency and integrity policies.

A way forward for improving Brazil's governance policy involves not so much creating new labels and norms but, rather, integrating and evaluating existing governance practices within Brazil's public administration. These practices are diverse and often scattered under various and other-than-governance labels, such as inter-agency collaboration. Brazil's case can also benefit international practitioners and scholars by highlighting the need to avoid evaluation designs that mistakenly treat a part of a policy as representative of the whole, without considering sector-specific approaches. This challenge is particularly acute when evaluating policies based on broad and overstretched concepts like governance. Consequently, conceptual clarity becomes crucial to deciding what to include in the evaluation.

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